The Impossible-Alone Task

Civic Skill: Cooperation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 4 (Learning) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will experience the necessity of cooperation by attempting a physical task that is genuinely impossible alone, discovering that interdependence is not a weakness but a productive fact.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can identify when I need someone else's help to succeed.
- I can contribute to a shared task and let someone else contribute too.
- I can say 'we did it' and mean it.

MATERIALS

- A challenge that physically requires two people: hold a hoop upright while threading a ball through it; carry a large object using only the string tied around it (not the object itself); pull a rope to move a platform with a cup of water on it without spilling
- Three versions of the challenge — easy, medium, and hard — so all groups experience genuine challenge
- Paper for planning ('what will you each do?')

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. SOLO ATTEMPT (3 min): Give one child the task alone. 'Try it.' They will fail or struggle. 'What's happening?' Resist explaining — let the child articulate the problem. 'What do you need that you don't have right now?'

2. PARTNERSHIP INTRODUCTION (2 min): 'I'm going to give you a partner. But here's the rule: you cannot touch the same part as your partner. You each have a different job. Talk about it first, then try.'

3. PLANNING (3 min): Pairs plan their approach. Educator prompts: 'Who will do what? What happens if one person stops? What does the other person need from you?'

4. ATTEMPT AND REFLECT (8 min): Pairs attempt the task. When they succeed: 'How did that work? What did you each do?' When they struggle: 'What needs to change? What is your partner needing from you right now?'

5. WHOLE GROUP DEBRIEF (5 min): 'Could anyone have done this alone? What did it feel like when both of you were working perfectly together?' Name the feeling of positive interdependence specifically.

EXTENSIONS

- Scale up: a three-person or whole-group impossible task
- Design their own impossible-alone challenge for another pair to solve
- Reflection: 'What is something in our classroom that everyone needs to cooperate for, even if it doesn't look like a challenge?'

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Does the child communicate with their partner during the task, or work around them?
- Key question: 'What would have happened if your partner hadn't been there?'
- Note: children who credit only themselves after a shared success — this is a teachable moment, not a failure

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were there pairs where one child dominated? How did you intervene without taking over?
- What does the experience of genuine interdependence feel like compared to parallel work? Did children name that difference?
- How could you structure more 'impossible alone' moments into your everyday program — not as set activities but as natural conditions?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 4 (Learning). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.